

CHALLENGERS

SHARIF AND BENAZIR BHUTTO LAUNCH CAMPAIGNS TO TAKE CONTROL OF THE FUTURE OF PAKISTAN

cover story PAKISTAN

■ By Hasan Zaidi in Karachi



In early November, President Pervez Musharraf had defiantly stated in a television interview that he was indefatigable in the face of tremendous international pressure and domestic political unrest. "I don't get tired," he said, "I just continue working." Yet the strain of holding off the inevitable may finally have been too much. On November 28, General Musharraf beat a strategic retreat, stepping down as army chief after nine years at the force's helm. And a day later, he was sworn in as a civilian President—the first time in Pakistan's history that a military coup-maker had dared to brave public life without his uniform and the constituency that is the source of his strength. He also plans to lift the state of Emergency that has held the Constitution in abeyance since November 3 and which has allowed him to handpick judges that struck down legal challenges to his re-election as the head of the state.

A week earlier, after having installed a caretaker cabinet and announcing general elections in January, Musharraf flew to Saudi Arabia in a last ditch attempt to convince the royal family to prevent his great political nemesis, deposed former prime minister Nawaz Sharif, from returning immediately from exile and adding fuel to the fire. The Saudis were unconvinced

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